The Quiet Art of Reading

A sample document for the Reflow Reader

The Reflow Reader takes the fixed geometry of a PDF and turns it into a stream of text that can be read like an EPUB. Instead of pinching and zooming around a fixed page, you can change the type size, line length and theme, and let the words settle into a shape that suits the screen in front of you.

> Extraction is only half the work. Reading order, paragraph detection and running-head removal are all heuristics, and the best result comes from combining several weak signals rather than trusting any single measurement. This paragraph is indented to demonstrate how the reader finds a new paragraph without a large vertical gap.

This sentence contains an exam-
ple of a word split across two lines, which the reflow engine repairs before it reaches your eyes.

No document ever leaves this browser tab. The file is read with the File API, parsed by pdf.js inside the page, and cached only in local storage. There is no account, no upload and no analytics.

Two Columns, One Reading Order

Magazines, journals and academic papers often set their body text in two or more columns. A naive extractor reads straight across the page, producing sentences that jump between unrelated paragraphs. The reader instead looks for a vertical gutter, groups the lines on either side, and reads the left column from top to bottom before moving to the right column.

Wide headings split a page into horizontal bands. Within each band the columns are read in order. This is enough for most newspapers, journals and reports. Complex grids, tables and sidebars remain outside the model.

A second paragraph in the left column illustrates the indentation cue. The reader also notices the change in line length and the end of a sentence. No single signal decides where a paragraph ends.

The right column begins here. In the original PDF it sits beside the left column, but in the reading view it simply follows it. The small page label above each section lets you compare the two representations when something looks wrong.

Headers and footers are detected by sampling pages across the document. A line that recurs in the same margin on enough pages is dropped from the reading view. Page numbers are removed on sight. Both behaviours can be switched off.

The sample on this page deliberately repeats its running head and page number so that you can toggle the option in Settings and watch them disappear or return. This line is short.

Typography is a set of choices for every reader and screen

Serif, sans or a dyslexia-friendly face; a tighter or looser line height; a narrow measure or a generous one. All of it can be changed while keeping your place in the document.

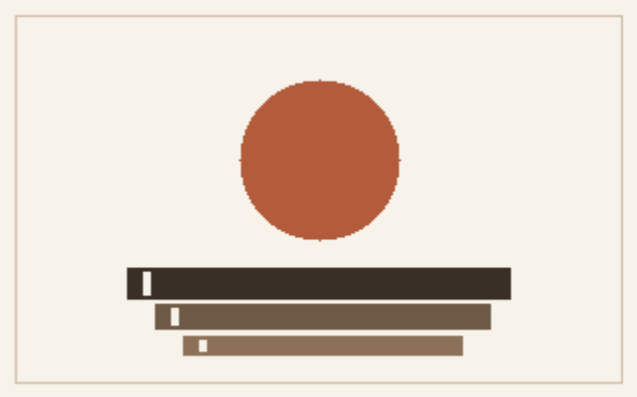


Figure 1. A raster image is kept in the reading order of the page.

What the Reader Can Do

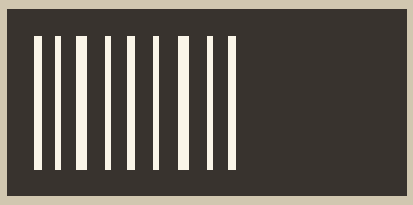
Open a PDF with the file picker or drag it onto the window. The title, page count and reading position are remembered for that document, keyed by a hash of its contents. Reopening the same file returns you to the same place.

Reading controls

Use the arrow keys, Page Up and Page Down, Space, Home and End. On a phone, swipe sideways in paginated mode. The progress bar and the page box at the bottom can take you anywhere in the document. The contents drawer is built from the PDF outline when one exists.

Text remains selectable, so the browser s own Find command works. The in-book search scans every page in the background and highlights matches on the page.

A note on quality

Reflow is a heuristic. Scanned pages have no text layer and are shown as images with an explanation. Pages with very little text fall back to the original view. Pages where the column model is uncertain keep their reflow but show a warning and a one-click switch. You can always compare against the page itself.

1. This footnote is set in a smaller size and is styled as small print rather than body copy.
2. It is still selectable and searchable, like every other piece of extracted text.